

When my birthday came around in June, I threw myself a massive party at the improv theater where I performed in downtown NYC. The boy I was interested in didn't show up because he was fighting with his girlfriend, so I got super-super-drunk. I ended up going home with two male friends and having a very fun but very ill-advised threesome (ill advised because they were colleagues and I was mixing business and pleasure). I took a too-expensive cab back up to my place in Harlem in the small hours of the morning and promptly passed out.

The next day, I woke up with a massive hangover, and I couldn't stop shaking. (Alcohol can exacerbate mental illness because it's a depressant.) My hangover eventually subsided, but later that night, I was still feeling very crappy. I also had not stopped convulsing, shuddering every so often between waves of nausea. I'd had bad hangovers before, but this was more than that. I was totally unable to eat. The mere thought of food caused the shaking to intensify. I tried to eat some cooked spinach, which I normally love, and I threw it up violently. Something was really wrong.

My sister-in-law drove to Brooklyn from Nyack and picked me up at the apartment of a girl I was casually seeing. She took me back to her and my brother's two-bedroom condo outside the city. I spent the next week in the same smelly gray pajamas, unable to get off their couch. I could barely move unless it was to blink. I stared off into nothing, basically comatose. I couldn't keep food down, but I also couldn't even get it into my mouth. I'd eat one piece of banana and shake for an hour. I moaned and cried. My whole body was in physical pain. I couldn't express what was wrong, and so I didn't talk. I did not sleep. In the middle of one of the nights I was there, I lay on the floor of my brother's bedroom, screaming and begging my brother to call 911 because I was convinced I was dying. They had a 2-year-old son, by the way. They could not also handle my grown-lady psychosis. Every second, I was more and more convinced I was having some kind of prolonged heart attack because my chest was in so much pain. I couldn't take a full breath. I thought I had to die to feel better.

Eventually I became okay enough (or annoying enough) to be allowed to go back to my apartment in Harlem. I was embarrassed to have been such a burden on my family. Luckily, I was working for a blog where people sometimes failed to show up to work due to *cocaine*. My taking some time because of my bad brain